Lesson 07: Grammar: Gerunds and Infinitives

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 2.4: Grammar Presentation-Gerunds and Infinitives; 2.5: Communication Practice; Gerunds and Infinitives.

In this lesson

You will learn how -ing forms (gerunds) and to + verb forms (infinitives) work in a sentence, which words they follow, and when the choice changes the meaning. Academic texts use them all the time to name processes, as in the reading "Coping Mechanisms": "Problem-solving focuses on locating the source of the problem."

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Identify a gerund as a subject, an object or the object of a preposition, and tell it apart from a progressive verb or an adjective.
- Use a singular verb after a gerund subject.
- Choose a gerund or an infinitive after common verbs, using the book's lists.
- Use infinitives of purpose and infinitives after adjectives and nouns.
- Explain the change in meaning after stop, remember, forget and regret.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
gerund	the -ing form of a verb used as a noun	Reading is fun.
infinitive	to + the base form of a verb	I want to live a long happy life.
base form	the verb with no ending and no "to"	live, help, be
object of a preposition	the noun or gerund after a preposition (in, about, for, of)	Jose is interested in reading that book.
progressive verb	be + -ing: an action in progress	The baby is sleeping soundly.
modal	a helping verb such as have to or used to, followed by the base form	Fatima has to visit the embassy.
infinitive of purpose	to + verb that gives the reason (Why?)	I went to the store to buy the missing ingredients.
verb + object + infinitive	a verb, then a person, then to + verb	His mother wants him to stay close to home.

Rules and explanations

Gerunds: -ing forms used as nouns

Function	Example
subject	Reading is fun.
object (after a verb)	I enjoy reading.
object of a preposition	Jose is interested in reading that book.

- A gerund subject is one action, so the verb is singular: Baking pies **is** my hobby. Two gerunds joined with "and" are plural: Baking pies and crocheting hats **are** my hobbies.
- **Verbs followed by gerunds:** admit, anticipate, appreciate, avoid, consider, defend, delay, deny, discontinue, discuss, dislike, enjoy, explain, fear, finish, go (in expressions: go camping), imagine, keep, mention, miss, practice, recommend, suggest, understand. Emily enjoys jogging in the mornings. I suggest enrolling in a math class.
- **After a preposition, use a gerund:** Jinan is excited about playing with her cousins.

Gerund, progressive verb or adjective?

- My hobby is baking pies. (gerund: you can reverse it: Baking pies is my hobby.)
- The baby is sleeping soundly. (verb: be + -ing, the progressive)
- The sleeping baby looks so peaceful. (adjective: it describes a noun)

Infinitives: to + base form

- "To" before a noun is a preposition, not an infinitive: I gave a gift to my mom. We studied from 6PM to 10PM.
- "Have to" and "used to" are modals + base form: Eçe used to live in Cairo, Egypt.
- "Be used to" is adjective + preposition, so a gerund follows: Ruth is used to waking up early.
- An infinitive as a subject is rare and sounds odd. Writers usually start with "It": It is important to wear a seatbelt.

Verbs, adjectives and nouns followed by infinitives

- **Verb + infinitive:** agree, appear, arrange, ask, attempt, choose, decide, demand, deserve, expect, fail, get, hope, learn, need, offer, pay, plan, pretend, seem, strive, struggle, tend, threaten, wait, want. Habib offered to buy me coffee.
- **Verb + noun/pronoun + infinitive:** advise, allow, ask, encourage, expect, force, invite, order, remind, tell. Need and want take both patterns: Geraldo wants to transfer to a university. His mother wants him to stay close to home.
- **Infinitive of purpose** (the answer to "Why?"). "In order" is optional, and the infinitive can come at the end or at the start: I am learning Arabic (in order) to communicate with my mother-in-law. (In order) to communicate with my mother-in-law, I am learning Arabic.
- **Adjective + infinitive:** Tomoki was surprised to see his mother at the store.

- **Noun + infinitive** (the infinitive comes after the noun and describes it): Your reluctance to help is frustrating. I am happy with his decision to take the day off. Common nouns: ability, chance, decision, goal, need, opportunity, plan, promise, way (full list: Table 8 in the lesson material). (In "I went to the store to buy ...", to buy does not describe the store: it is a purpose.)

Gerund or infinitive?

- **No real change in meaning:** begin, continue, hate, like, love, prefer, propose, start.
- **A big change in meaning:** forget, quit, regret, remember, stop, try. Cynthia stopped smoking (= she quit smoking). Cynthia stopped to smoke (= she stopped doing something so that she could smoke).

Verb	+ infinitive	+ gerund
stop	stop one activity in order to do another	quit an activity
remember / forget	(not) do a task that you need to do	(not) have a memory of a past action
regret	be sorry about bad news that you are giving now	be sorry about something you did in the past

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic often uses "that" + a verb after verbs like want and expect. English uses an object + infinitive: NOT My mother wants that I study medicine. Say: My mother wants me to study medicine.

Practice

Exercise 4. Verb or gerund? Is the -ing word a verb, a gerund or an adjective? Options for every item: a) verb b) gerund c) adjective. (In item 1, decide about "learning".)

1. The students were learning writing skills.
2. The next step is reviewing notes.
3. Elena's mistake was trusting people she didn't know.
4. She was talking to her friends and having fun.
5. The police saw the speeding car immediately.
6. She is eliminating injustice.
7. The increasing prices have caused a lot of uncertainty.

Exercise 5. Gerunds in Chapter 2's reading. What is the function of the -ing word(s) in bold? Options for every item: a) subject b) object c) object of a preposition d) not a gerund.

1. People have many different strategies for **dealing** with stressful situations.
2. When you are **facing** a stressful situation, learn to relax ...
3. **Finding** emotional support from others or **asking** for help can be instrumental ...

4. Instead of **facing** the problem, the person decides to reject its existence ...
5. ... may accuse her of **being** the angry one instead of **admitting** that he is actually the angry one.
6. A process involves **defining** the issue, **brainstorming** alternatives, **evaluating** and **choosing** between these alternatives, and **implementing** solutions.
7. **Developing** a plan can help lessen stress ...
8. Sigmund Freud ... is credited with **popularizing** the idea of denial.
9. **Thinking** about tragic events helps people prepare ...
10. ... people enjoy **reading** about, **watching**, and **analyzing** tragedies.

Exercise 9. Infinitives in Chapter 2's reading. What is the function of the words in bold? Options for every item: a) subject b) object c) infinitive of purpose d) adjective followed by infinitive e) noun followed by infinitive f) not an infinitive.

1. Anticipation is a way **to reduce** the stress of a difficult challenge.
2. A coping mechanism is a method **to deal** with stress or conflict.
3. The brain's response **to worry** enhances the effectiveness of this strategy.
4. It is a way for a person **to "master"** or minimize the effect of a stressful situation.
5. ... strengthen your ability **to seek** emotional support.
6. ... it is a useful response **to** both simple and complex issues.
7. People of all ages and cultures respond **to** humor.
8. Denial is the refusal **to accept** truth or fact.
9. ... a person is faced with a fact too uncomfortable **to accept**.
10. ... the person decides **to reject** its existence or minimize its importance.
11. ... a new imaginary world where they do not have **to face** an uncomfortable feeling or memory.
12. ... it is important **to prioritize** your physical, mental, and social well-being.
13. It is also important **to maintain** your mental health.
14. It is when a person tries **to "disconnect"** from a traumatic or stressful event.

Exercise 10. Change in meaning? Is there a difference in meaning? Options for every item: a) different b) same.

1. Felipe hates going to the dentist. Felipe hates to go to the dentist.
2. Tamara tried to shut the window. Tamara tried shutting the window.
3. Lee started studying every day. Lee started to study every day.
4. Sukinah loves to receive flowers. Sukinah loves receiving flowers.
5. I regret saying those words. I regret to say these words.
6. Laura forgot to give him the message. Laura forgot giving him the message.
7. Hadi continues to make progress with his behavior. Hadi continues making progress with his behavior.
8. Mai prefers to join a club on campus. Mai prefers joining a club on campus.

9. Alejandro remembers to pack a lunch. Alejandro remembers packing a lunch.
10. Reza stopped drinking soda. Reza stopped to drink a soda.

Exercise 12. Gerund or infinitive? Choose a) or b).

1. Isaac agreed _____ to Disneyland with us. a) to go b) going
2. I denied _____ the last slice of cake. a) to take b) taking
3. Melissa enjoys _____ for her patients in the hospital. She's a great nurse. a) to care b) caring
4. We plan _____ a new house next year. a) to buy b) buying
5. Elijah keeps _____ late. He never arrives on time! a) to wake up b) waking up
6. I appreciate you _____ me time to prepare for the meeting. a) to give b) giving
7. The boy wants _____ at his grandmother's house, but he must go home. a) to stay b) staying
8. The teacher promised _____ the final grades by Monday morning. a) to give b) giving
9. The teacher suggested _____ an appointment with a counselor. a) to make b) making
10. Mufeed refused _____ to the doctor even though he was in so much pain. a) to go b) going

More items: lesson material, Exercise 12 (items 11-20). Your tutor can check them.

Exercise 13. Correcting errors. Each sentence has one mistake. Find it and correct it. The first one is done for you.

1. He read the whole book without use a dictionary. (without using)
2. She insisted in driving me home.
3. I enjoy to walk in the park.
4. He went to shop after work.
5. I decided buy a new car.
6. Find a good job is important.
7. Is important to find a good job.
8. I decided to bought a new car.
9. He wants that I drive.
10. It's important to me to find a job.
11. I called the company for make an appointment.
12. I use to live with my parents. Now I live alone.
13. The teacher expects we do the homework.
14. It's necessary for he to be on time.
15. I need to went to the library last weekend.

Speak with your tutor

- "Ask me the questions from Exercises 14 and 15 (Do you enjoy playing sports? What do you hope to do next year?). Correct my gerunds and infinitives."

- "I will do Exercises 3, 6, 7 and 8 aloud (... is exciting!; I went to the beach to ...; I am excited to ...). Correct me."
- "Check my answers to Exercise 11 in the lesson material. Then give me five new sentences with stop, remember or forget and ask me what each one means."

Read aloud

1. Baking pies is my hobby. Baking pies and crocheting hats are my hobbies.
2. Emily enjoys /z/ jogging in the mornings.
3. Habib offered /d/ to buy me coffee.
4. I am learning Arabic in order to communicate with my mother-in-law.
5. Cynthia stopped smoking. Cynthia stopped to smoke.
6. Word stress: GER·und, in·FIN·i·tive, pro·GRES·sive.

Writing task

How I cope with stress. Write a paragraph of 120 to 160 words about the ways you deal with stress as a student. Use at least three gerunds (one as a subject, one after a verb from the list, one after a preposition) and three infinitives (one after a verb, one infinitive of purpose, one after an adjective). Underline them.

Checklist:

- A gerund subject has a singular verb (Exercising helps me ...).
- After a preposition, I used -ing (by talking, instead of worrying).
- I checked each verb in the lists: enjoy, avoid, keep + -ing; decide, plan, need + to.
- After want, ask or encourage + a person, I used to + verb (My friends encourage me to ...).
- For a purpose, I used to + verb, not "for" + verb.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Gerunds and Gerund Phrases as Objects of Prepositions: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CEcdud_Z_6c
- Infinitives, Part II: verb + object + infinitive: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bwaDmVNrdIg
- Infinitives, Part III: a change in meaning: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8y3Oed9XwIo

Answer key

Exercise 4 (book): 1. a) verb 2. b) gerund 3. b) gerund 4. a) verb 5. c) adjective 6. a) verb 7. c) adjective. (The book's item 7 says "The increasing prices has caused"; correct English is "have caused", because "prices" is plural.)

Exercise 5 (book): 1. c) 2. d) (are facing is a progressive verb) 3. a) 4. c) 5. c) 6. b) 7. a) 8. c) 9. a) 10. b)

Exercise 9 (book): 1. e) 2. e) 3. f) (worry is a noun here) 4. e) 5. e) 6. f) (to + noun phrase) 7. f) (to + noun) 8. e) 9. d) 10. b) 11. f) (have to is a modal) 12. d) 13. d) 14. b)

Exercise 10 (book): 1. b) same 2. a) different 3. b) same 4. b) same 5. a) different 6. a) different 7. b) same 8. b) same 9. a) different 10. a) different

Exercise 12 (book): 1. a) to go 2. b) taking 3. b) caring 4. a) to buy 5. b) waking up 6. b) giving 7. a) to stay 8. a) to give 9. b) making 10. a) to go

Exercise 13 (book): 2. insisted on driving 3. enjoy walking 4. went shopping (go + -ing is the usual expression for activities) 5. decided to buy 6. Finding a good job is important. 7. It is important 8. decided to buy 9. wants me to drive 10. It's important for me to find a job. (Note: "important to me" is also correct English when you mean that it matters to you personally; the book practises It is + adjective + for + person + infinitive.) 11. called the company to make 12. I used to live 13. expects us to do 14. for him to be 15. I needed to go

My notes